The Global Collaboratory on the History of Labour Relations, 1500 – 2000: Methodological Paper

Dataset: Belarus 2000 (Russian Empire Borders 1800)

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Introduction

This dataset on labour relations in the Republic of Belarus for the cross-section of the year 2000 has been compiled in the framework of the Global Collaboratory on the History of Labour Relations, a project of the International Institute of Social History in Amsterdam, the Netherlands. The dataset for Belarus is meant as a part of the larger dataset on geographical area indicated as "Russia" for the cross-section of the year 2000. Because the latter needs to be backwardly comparable with the set for the 1800 cross-section in terms of territory, we have chosen to make separate sets of data on labour relations for the Russian Federation, Ukraine, Belarus, Latvia, Lithuania, Estonia and Moldova, and combine these in order to arrive at a territorial entity that is backwardly comparable to the Russian Empire with the borders it had in 1800. This entity is termed "Russian Empire (borders 1800)."

The focus of this paper is to lay out the method by which we have applied the Collaboratory's taxonomy to the results of Population Census of the Republic of Belarus of 1999, the main source on the basis of which we have compiled this dataset.[1] The reader will find general information on Belarus at the turn of the century, the aforementioned Population Census, the method by which we divided the Belarussian population over each labour relation, and finally some remarks on data that is "hidden" in the Population Census of 1999. We would like to remind the users that this is the first version of this dataset. It provides a global overview of the different labour relations prevalent in Belarus, determined as precisely as the currently available data have allowed us to do so. The current dataset thus is a starting point for analysis, and can be expanded in later versions.

[1] For a further elaboration on the taxonomy for the Collab's taxonomy, see Karin Hofmeester, Jan Luassen, Leo Lucassen, Rombert Stapel, and Richard Zijdeman, 'The Global Collaboratory on the History of Labour Relations, 1500-2000: Background, Set-Up, Taxonomy and Applications' (2015) on the projects website. Url: https://datasets.socialhistory.org/dataset.xhtml?persistentId=hdl:10622/4OGRAD (accessed 21-09-2017, 15:57)

Belarus At the Turn of the Century

On 24 August 1991, the Belarussian Supreme Soviet — the Soviet legislative body — declared the independence of the Belarusian Republic from the Soviet Union. Located in Eastern Europe, it is bordered by the Russian Federation in the east, Ukraine to the south, Poland to the west, and Lithuania and Latvia to the north. The new republic retained the same territory as the Belarusian Soviet Socialist Republic, which compromises 207,600 square kilometres, administratively divided over six regions (*oblasti*) and the city of Minsk, the Belarusian capital.



Figure 1: A map of the Republic of Belarus among neighbouring states with its six regions and the city of Minsk. Source: Olav Hofland (2017).

During the main part of the 1990s, Western analysts and policymakers commonly considered Belarus to be a "transition state" on its way to become a "normal" liberal democracy based on the European model. But by the end of the 1990s, it became very clear that Belarus had taken its own path of economic and political development.

Politically, the republic has developed in a presidential democracy in which the president can rule by decree and keeps the legislative bodies firmly in check. This has been achieved by the incumbent president Alexander Lukashenko, who replaced the former president Stanislav Shushkevich through the first direct presidential elections in July 1994. By state-engineered referenda in 1995 and 1996, Lukashenko consolidated his position vis-à-vis the parliament,

and made himself into an implacable enemy of the Belarusian opposition. In spite of these developments, to which he owed his nomination as "Europe's last dictator" in the West, Lukashenko remains very popular among the Belarusian population and retains a solid lead over his rivals in all opinion polls.[2]

Also in terms of economy, the government has retained a far stronger position in comparison with its post-Communist neighbours, to such an extent that the economist Mario Nuti has named Belarus "a command economy without central planning." Most of the republic's enterprises remained controlled by the government, either by direct state-ownership or by the possibility for the state to retain a "golden share" in privatized companies. Foreign investment is almost non-existent. In spite of all this, the Belarusian economy performed better than the economies of Russia and Ukraine during the 1990s. During this period the state has been able to keep domestic and foreign indebtedness very low, successfully fight criminality an corruption and keep its unemployment rates relatively low.[3]

It must be noted, however, that Belarus has been both politically and economically dependent on the Russian Federation, with whom it established a Union State in 1996. Russian leaders have always supported Lukashenka in elections, and both states have a well-developed joint defence program. Furthermore, the Russian Federation sells gas cheaply to Belarus and a significant part of the Belarusian population is dependent on labour opportunities on the Russian job market.

Undoubtedly, these trends in Belarusian politics and economy did have an effect on the labour relations that prevail among its population. Knowledge of the specific politico-economic context is a necessary component in the elaborate analysis of labour relations in Belarus, and should be taken into regard, when using our dataset.

The Population Census of 1999

Our dataset on labour relations in Belarus for the cross-section of the year 2000 is mainly based on the results of the Population Census of the Republic of Belarus, conducted by the latter's Ministry of Statistics and Analysis in 1999. This was the eight census ever to take place in

[2] See David Marples, 'Europe's Last Dictatorship: The Roots and Perspectives of Authoritarianism in "White Russia"', *Europe-Asia Studies* 57, no. 6 (September 2005), 896-7.

[3] Mario Nuti gives an excellent overview of macroeconomic trends in Belarus during the 1990s. See D. Mario Nuti, 'Belarus: A Command Economy without Central Planning', *Russian & East European Finance and Trade* 36, no. 4 (Jul. – Aug., 2000), 45-79.

Belarus, and the very first one since its independence from the Soviet Union. It was conducted in accordance with modern international standards. Only permanent residents of Belarus were included in the census. In order to minimize distortion by domestic migration, the census was taken during the week from 16 to 23 February, as the population is characteristically less mobile during winter months.[4]

The results of the census were published in 2001 in Minsk in multiple volumes and can be partly accessed through the website of Belarus' National Committee for Statistics (Belstat).[5] The results provide reliable data on the full Belarusian population, based on different socio-demographic indicators such as gender, age, ethnicity (*natsional'nost'*), education, marital status, and employment. In our determination of the entire population, economically active population, and labour relations for Belarus, we have relied on these results whenever possible. The only exception to this rule was our estimate of the number of invalids, in which we have used data from the results of the later 2009 Belarusian population census (see below).

The Entire Population and Distribution by Sex, Age, Place of Habitation and Marital Status

We have used the second volume of the published results of the population census of 2009, titled *Population of Belarus: Size and Composition*, to determine the entire population of Belarus and its distribution by sex, age, place of habitation and marital status in 1999.[6] We have done so, because the relevant printed volumes of the 1999 census were not available for us at the time of compiling our dataset, nor were these results available online. In *Population of Belarus* the editors included data from the 1999 census in order to compare it with the results of the 2009 census. From this publication we have used the following tables:

- 2.2 — Population dynamics in the Republic of Belarus, regions and Minsk city by age group[7]

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[4] See L. P. Shakhot'ko, 'Naselenie belarusi: nekotorye rezul'taty perepisi 1999 g.', *Belorusskii ekonomicheskii zhurnal,* no. 4 (2000), 31-32.

[5] The aforementioned Ministry of Statistics and Analysis was reorganized in 2008 and subsequently renamed the National Committee for Statistics (Belstat). Results and information on the 1999 and 2009 census, can be retrieved online. [URL] http://www.belstat.gov.by/informatsiya-dlya-respondenta/perepis-naseleniya/ (Accessed 28-09-2017, 15:04).

[6] See V.I. Zinovskii (ed.), *Perepis' naseleniia 2009. Tom II. Naselenie respubliki belarus': ego chislenost i sostav* (Minsk: Natsional'nyi statisticheskii komitet respubliki belarus', 2010). Can be retrieved online. [URL] http://www.belstat.gov.by/informatsiya-dlya-respondenta/perepis-naseleniya/perepis-naseleniya-2009-goda/statisticheskie-publikatsii/statisticheskie-sborniki_2/index_545/ (Accessed 27-09-2017, 12:33).

[7] Ibid., 214-235. Henceforth referred to in running text as [Zinovskii table 2.2]

- 3.2 — Number of males and females aged 15 years and over by marital status[8]

The entire population of the Republic of Belarus in 1999, counted 10,045,237 people. In our database one can find how the population was further distributed by sex, age, place of habitation, and marital status. This information can be found in all records with a "P" in the "Type_activity" column.

Labour Relations

Most of the data relevant for the determination of labour relations in the Republic of Belarus are found in the census volume titled *Economically Active and Not Economically Active Population, Employment and Unemployment in the Republic of Belarus*.[9] The following tables from this source have been used:

- 2.2 — Urban and rural economically active population by age[10]
- 3.15 — Urban and rural employed population by status in main employment[11]
- 3.17 — Employed population by age group and status in main employment[12]
- 3.2 — Employment[13]
- 4.1 — Unemployment rate[14]
- 4.3 — Unemployment by age and place of residence[15]
- 5.2 — Urban and rural population not economically active by age[16]

This source only provides data on the economic (non-)activity of the Belarusian population older than 14 years. Those individuals who belong to the age group 0-14 are automatically alleged not to be economically active. With regards to occupational information, this source does only provide very broad indicators — such as "specialists of the highest level of qualification" or "qualified workers in agriculture, forestry, hunting, fishery and aquaculture".

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[8] Ibid., 346-352. Henceforth referred to in running text as [Zinovskii table 3.2]

[9] See G.I. Gasiuk (ed.), *Itogi perepisi naseleniia respubliki belarus' 1999. Ekonomicheski aktivnoe i neaktivnoe naselenie, zaniatost' i bezrabotitsa v respublike belarus'. Statisticheskii sbornik* (Minsk: Ministerstvo statistiki I analiza respubliki belarus', 2001).

[10] Ibid., 36. Henceforth referred to in running text as [Gasiuk table 2.2]

[11] Ibid.,72. Henceforth referred to in running text as [Gasiuk table 3.15]

[12] Ibid., 76. Henceforth referred to in running text as [Gasiuk table 3.17]

[13] Ibid.,84. Henceforth referred to in running text as [Gasiuk table 3.2]

[14] Ibid., 96. Henceforth referred to in running text as [Gasiuk table 4.1]

[15] Ibid., 98. Henceforth referred to in running text as [Gasiuk table 4.3]

[16] Ibid., 118. Henceforth referred to in running text as [Gasiuk table 5.2]

Therefore we could not use these data to get an insight in the occupational structure of the Belarusian population. Nevertheless, these tables give enough information to determine the distribution of labour relations 1, 3, 4a012a, 4b012b, 5, 13, 14018, 1410181 and 12a012b014018.

In our database, records with an "L" in the "Type_activity" column contain data on labour relations. The type of labour relation is indicated in the column "Labour_rel_01". Below follows an explanation of how each of the labour relations indicated above have been determined.

Labour relation 1 — "Cannot work or cannot be expected to work". The population that we have classified with this labour relation is composed of four different parts. First , we have used the age-delimiters to separate those who are too young to work (younger than 15 years) from the entire population as indicated in [Zinovskii table 2.2]. In order to isolate the population that is too old to be expected to work we have taken the economically non-active population above working age (16-54 for women; 16-59 for men) in [Gasiuk table 5.2]. In this way we have separated the pensioners who do not have to work or who cannot work from the total population above working age.

Thirdly, we have separated the students (*uchashiesia, studenty*) that indicated to be unemployed in [Gasiuk table 4.1] from the population older than 14 years. This is the only reference to the studying population older than 14 years we have currently been able to identify. Consequently, we underestimate of the amount of students to be included in labour relation 1. Students that are employed or economically inactive cannot be separated from the population in labour relations 4a012a, 4b012b, 13, 14018, 1410181, 12a012b014018 and 5, and are therefore included in those labour relations.

Lastly, we have estimated the number of invalids of working age by using the population that indicated pensions for invalidity (*pensiiu po invalidnosti*) as their main source of income in the population census of 2009 as a proxy.[17]

Labour relation 3 — "Unemployed". We have classified the unemployed individuals indicated as "unemployed (excluding students and pensioners)" (*bezrabotnye (bez uchashchikhsia,*

[17] See 'Tablitsa 4.3. Naselenie otdel'nykh vozrastnykh grupp po osnovomu istochniku sredstv k sushchestvovaniiu', *Perepis' naselenia Respublika Belarus' 2009 goda.* Accessible online. [URL] http://www.belstat.gov.by/upload-belstat/upload-belstat-pdf/perepis_2009/4.3-0.pdf (accessed 27-09-2017, 17:42).

studentov i pensionerov)) and "pensioners" (*pensionery*) in [Gasiuk table 4.1] as this belonging to this labour relation.

Labour relation 4a012a —"Leading producers and Self-employed leading producers". We have classified the individuals who indicated to be "own-account workers" (*samostoiatel'no zaniatye*) included in [Gasiuk tables 3.15 and 3.17] as working in this labour relation. According to the census' definitions this group consists of individuals who autonomously carry out professional or commercial activities on their own farm or enterprise without using fully employed waged labourers. Because this group of "self-employed" thus includes at least some individuals that produce merely to sustain their household, and others who provide goods and services for the market, we have chosen to use a combined labour relation.

Labour relation 4b012b —"Kin producers and Self-employed kin producers". We have classified the individuals who indicated to be "unpaid family workers" (*pomogaiushchie chleny sem'i*) as shown in [Gasiuk tables 3.15 and 3.17] as working in this labour relation. According to the census' definitions this group consists of individuals who work without salary at a private family enterprise owned by a relative. We have chosen to use a combined labour relation, because it is unclear whether these individuals work for commercial enterprises or self-sustaining households.

Labour relation 5 — "Kin non-producers". The population that we have classified as working under labour relation 5 is composed of two parts. Firstly, we have taken the economically non-active men in the age group 15-59 and women in the age group 15-54 indicated in [Gasiuk table 5.2] and subtracted the estimated number of invalids that are assigned to labour relation 1, as described above. Secondly, we have added a leftover category consisting of individuals older than 14 years and those that did not indicate their age, who did not indicate whether they were economically active or not. We have calculated this as the difference between the entire population older than 14 years in [Zinovskii table 2.2] and the population in [Gasiuk table 2.2] and [Gasiuk table 5.2] combined.

As mentioned above, the population classified as working in this labour relation is probably overestimated, as it includes economically non-active students. The fact that individuals in the age group of 15-24 make up the lion's share of the population classified as labour relation 5, seems to confirm this.

Labour relation 13 — "Employers". We have classified the individuals who indicated to be "employers" (*rabotodateli*) as shown in [Gasiuk tables 3.15 and 3.17] as working in this labour relation. According to the census' definitions this group consists of individuals who own a farm or an enterprise, or autonomously carry out professional or commercial activities, and make use of fully employed waged labourers.

Labour relation 14018 — "Wage earners working for the market and for non-market institutions". We have classified the individuals who indicated to be "employees" (*rabotaiushchie po naimu*) as shown in [Gasiuk tables 3.15 and 3.17] as working in this labour relation. According to the census' definitions this group consists of individuals who work on a contractual basis at an organisation and are guaranteed of a salary, independent from the organisation's revenue. This definition explicitly includes all of those who have a paid position, including military servicemen and those who work in religious institutions. We have thus used a combined labour relation, because we cannot distinguish between waged labour for the market and waged labour for non-market institutions on the basis of the census results. Moreover, as mentioned above, it remains very hard to make a difference between private and state-owned enterprise in Belarus.

Labour relation 1410181 — "Sharecropping for the market and for non-market institutions". We have classified the individuals who indicated to be "member of producers' cooperative" (*chleny proizvodstvennykh kooperativov*) as shown in [Gasiuk tables 3.15 and 3.17] as working in this labour relation. According to the census' definitions this group includes all of those who work at an enterprise organized as a cooperative in which each member has equal duties and a right to an equal share of the organization's revenue. We have applied a combined labour relation, as we cannot distinguish between those cooperatives that produce for the market and those that produce for non-market institutions on the basis of the census results.

Labour relation 12a012b014018 — "Combined commodified labour". We have classified all individuals who were included in the employed population (*zaniatoe naselenie)* but did not indicate their status in main employment (*zaniatost na osnovoi rabote*) in [Gasiuk tables 3.15 and 3.17] as working in this labour relation. This is thus a left-over category to which all employed individuals were assigned who we could not assign to groups that worked in other

labour relations. Therefore we have used a nominator that combines all commodified labour.

Having applied this methodology to the entire population of the Republic of Belarus as it is recorded in the results of the census of 1999, we derive at the following distribution of labour relations among the republic's entire population:

Labour Relation	Total	Percentage (of total labour relations)
1	4,048,118	40,30%
3	276,497	2,75%
4a012a	58,049	0,58%
4b012b	901	0,01%
5	1,273,727	12,68%
13	18,330	0,18%
14018	4,358,212	43,39%
1410181	10,369	0,10%
12a12b014018	1,034	0,01%
Total	**10045237**	**100,00%**

Table 1 The distribution of labour relations in the Republic of Belarus in 1999

Hidden Information

The results of the census of 1999 did not allow us to separate isolate individuals from the population assigned to the labour relations above, about whom we are sure that they should be assigned to another labour relation. These "hidden" groups will briefly be discussed below.

Conscripts. In Belarus, military service for a period of 18 months is mandatory for all men between in the age group 18-27. The *Stateman's Yearbook 2002* states that there were at least 40,000 conscripts serving in the Belarusian armed forces in 1999.[18]

Convict labourers. According to Mitchel Roth's encyclopaedia on prison systems worldwide, all prisoners in Belarusian prisons, except for pre-trial detainees, are required to work.[19] The

[18] Barry Turner (ed.), *The Stateman's Yearbook 2002 (London: Macmillan, 2002),* 277.
[19] Mitchel P. Roth, *Prisons and Prison Systems. A Global Encyclopedia* (Westport, Connecticut and London: Greewood Press, 2006), 30.

United Nations Office on Drugs and Crimes reports that there were 56,470 male and 2,797 female convicts in Belarusian prisons.[20]

Both conscripts and convict labourers should have been assigned to labour relation 8 (obligatory workers), but we have not been able to isolate these people within the census data.

Child Labour. Only the population that is older than 14 years has been included in the census of 1999 as eligible to work. We therefore cannot know if child labour exists among the population of Belarus on the basis of the census. [This has to be expanded, because estimates are surely available.]

Employed in the shadow economy and labour migration to the Russian Federation. [The size of the shadow economy in post-soviet states has been estimated in a couple of sources, which have to be included in later versions of this database.]

A. **The Shadow Economy and Labour Migration to Russian Federation. There is a large group of men included in LabRel 5. This phenomenon should be further analysed in order to find an explanation. But it is highly probable that men were engaged in the informal economy (characteristic for transition states in the 1990s) or seasonal labour in the Russian Federation. This does not show up in the census results and therefore led to an overrepresentation in LabRel 5.**

[20] UNODC, *The Seventh United Nations Survey on Crime Trends and the Operations of Criminal Justice Systems (1998-2000)*, 34. [URL] http://www.unodc.org/pdf/crime/seventh_survey/7pc.pdf (Accessed 28-09-2017, 18:43).